

4.1.1 SMS

Short Message Service (SMS) is a service available on most digital mobile phones, which permits the sending of short messages—also known as text messages, messages, or more colloquially SMSes, texts or even txts, between mobile phones, other hand-held devices and even landline telephones.

SMS is believed to have been invented by Matti Makkonen, a civil servant from Finland, in 1982. He presented the idea in a pizzeria in Copenhagen, during a conference of mobile phone communications. Initially conceptualised as Message Handling Services, SMS was proposed to be included in the GSM digital mobile phone standard as early as 1984 by Finland, Sweden, and Norway.

Though SMS was originally designed as a part of GSM, it is now available on a wide range of networks, including 3G. However, not all text-messaging systems use SMS, and some notable alternate implementations of the concept include SkyMail and Short Mail, both in Japan. E-mail messaging from phones, as popularised by i-mode and the RIM BlackBerry, also typically use standard mail protocols such as SMTP over TCP/IP, not SMS.

The Short Message Service - Point to Point (SMS-PP) is different as compared to the Short Message Service - Cell Broadcast (SMS-CB), which latter allows messages (advertising, public information, etc.) to be broadcast to all mobile users in a specified geographical area.

Messages are sent via a store-and-forward mechanism to a Short Message Service Centre (SMSC), which attempts to send the message to the recipient, and possibly retry if the user is not reachable. Both Mobile Terminated (MT) (messages sent to a mobile handset) and Mobile Originating (MO) (those that are sent from the mobile handset) operations are supported. Message delivery is the best option, but there are no guarantees